

COLOUR LASER PRINTERS

Samsung CLP-300

Decent overall

Samsung's new CLP-300 colour laser is touted as the smallest colour laser in the world, and we agree with that claim. This smart-looking printer has been designed the ground up as an entry-level colour laser for professionals.

The printer has just a single button and four LED indicators—one for each toner. The paper tray holds 150 sheets and juts out from the bottom. The toner cartridges are small cylindrical tubes and slide into their respective grooves—the black cartridge is bigger; good, considering it will be used more. The photo conductor drum can be removed, and the printer uses a carousel mechanism—each colour has to be developed on the same drum in four different loads.

The printer can be connected to a PC via USB, but you can also get the CLP-300N, which adds an Ethernet port for network printing. Installation was a breeze, and all you get is drivers and a status panel called Smart Panel. The status window is fairly informative,

and provides realistic toner usage. The driver is fairly comprehensive and has numerous options to play around with.

Samsung claims a speed of 16 pages for black, and the printer achieved 14 ppm. Our laser printer test document, consisting of six pages, was printed in 1 minute and 40 seconds—and hence falls just short of its claimed 4 ppm for colour. The photo document took 36 seconds to print; the delay can be attributed to the carousel mechanism the printer uses. The Combi-document was printed in just 29 seconds—a fair speed.

On the quality front, the Samsung CLP-300 saturated the black, killing vividity. Reverse-text (yellow on black) showed traces of black. Finer details were repro-



duced perfectly, except in the areas immediately surrounding dark areas of the printout. Colour gradation was also good, but we've seen better...

The printer costs Rs 15,500, and the four cartridges retail at Rs 10,500. The black toner is rated to give 2,000 pages, but the colour cartridges manage only 1,000 pages. The cost per page is similar to what's on offer from competing vendors.

Overall, Samsung's CLP-300 offers decent print quality, acceptable speeds, and reasonable pricing. However, keep in mind that this printer will not do justice to graphics-heavy work.

Specifications

16 ppm (black); 4 ppm (colour); 300 MHz; 32 MB memory (max); 24,200 pages duty cycle; USB 2.0; 150-sheet paper capacity; manual duplexing

Price: Rs 15,500

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Print Speed	★★★★●
Print Quality	★★★★●
Value for money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●

HP LaserJet 2600n

Good for small workgroups

The HP LaserJet 2600n is an entry-level colour laser printer with an Ethernet port; a version without inbuilt Ethernet is also available.

The LaserJet 2600n is fairly bulky, but clever design makes it look compact. The paper cassette is located at the bottom, and fits snugly inside the body. It can hold up to 250 sheets; you can increase this by adding an optional paper cassette. A manual paper feed lets you feed in a single sheet at a time.

The 2600n is targeted at workgroups, so it has a two-line LCD display. This is placed at an awkward angle; you'll have to bend to be able to see it, and it's not backlit. It's handy when setting up networking, or while troubleshooting. Apart from drivers, you also get Business Marketing Toolkit—links to How-Tos for marketing material, tutorials on Microsoft

Office products, and more.

The front of the printer pops open to reveal the cartridges. Installation is simple. The developer unit is on the inside of the front panel, so you have to be careful not to drop anything on it.

HP claims 8 ppm for black printouts, and this one managed between 6 and 7. The same ppm speed is claimed for colour, but our six-page test document took 1 minute and 5 seconds to complete—reasonable for this category of printers.

The 2600n delivered crisp test printouts, and even 2-point text was sharply reproduced and perfectly legible. With the Combi-document, finer details were spot on, and even colour gradations



were near-perfect. In the photo-target document, only skin tone lacked a little.

Cartridges cost Rs 13,515. The black cartridge is rated at 2,500 pages, and colour cartridges at 2,000. Cost per page works out to Rs 1.20 for black and Rs 1.70 for colour. Decent print speeds, good quality printouts, and reasonable pricing and running costs making this a good printer for small workgroups.

Specifications

600 dpi; 35,000 pages duty cycle; 8 ppm (black and colour); 16 MB memory (max); USB 2.0, Ethernet 10/100, 250-sheet input paper cassette; manual duplexing

Price: Rs 19,999

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Print Speed	★★★★●
Print Quality	★★★★●
Value for money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●